

Sport

Spartans keep up the pressure as they overcome Stripes

 **SIMON FARRUGIA**

Hamrun Spartans dealt with the pressure that they had to win their tricky match against Birkirkara, when they beat the Stripes by two goals to nil. Luke Montebello was the toast of the town as the Spartans striker scored both goals, one in each half.

This win means that Hamrun hold on to second place, two points adrift of League leaders Floriana.

This was the second match between these two sides in the past days since last week they met in the Izibet FA Trophy with the Stripes making it into the semi finals after emerging winners following a penalty shoot out.

Both teams wanted the points from this match for different reasons.

Hamrun Spartans to keep the pressure on leaders Floriana whereas Birkirkara in order to continue their fight for a European slot.

Hamrun took the lead in their first attack on 21 minutes when a long range shot by Ryan Camenzuli hit striker Luke Montebello deceiving the opposing goalkeeper and ending in the corner of the net.

The Stripes reaction was rather a slow one and a Coppola header was saved by Marchetti

On the half hour a Prsa free kick ended inches wide.

And Hamrun went near to double their lead ten minutes from the break when off a Prsa free kick, in came Freitas whose shot was cleared off the line by Zibo.

On the stroke of half time

Photo © Nicholas Falzon



Birkirkara nearly drew level when a Kurt Zammit header missed by a whisker.

The Spartans couldn't have asked for a better start to the second half when on 49 minutes they were awarded a penalty after goalkeeper Zapytowski brought down Jonny. From the resultant kick Luke Montebello made no mistake.

Hamrun were now dominating the proceedings and in the 54th minute Jonny set Mbong whom with only Zapytowski to beat, the Polish goalkeeper was on the alert to block the Hamrun midfielder.

With Birkirkara trying to save the match, Hamrun were now operating on the counter.

And on 65 minutes they nearly sealed the match when off a Freitas cross from the left flank a Jonny header ended inches wide.

Birkirkara were dealt a further blow a few minutes later when Diakite was given the marching orders for a second bookable offence.

But it was the Stripes who went near eighteen minutes

from the end when off a corner from the left side Maia hit the crossbar.

BOV CHALLENGE LEAGUE	
Yesterday	
Tarxien-Fgura.....	0-1
Attard-Zebbug.....	0-6
Melita-Zurrieq.....	5-0
Msida-St. Andrews.....	1-3

STANDINGS										
	P	W	D	L	F	A	Pts			
Floriana	22	17	3	2	48	10	54			
Hamrun	22	16	4	2	50	14	52			
Sliema	22	12	6	4	24	11	42			
Marsaxlokk	22	9	7	6	34	22	34			
Hibernians	22	9	6	7	25	20	33			
Naxxar	22	8	7	7	27	31	31			
Birkirkara	22	8	6	8	22	23	30			
Balzan	22	7	8	7	24	26	29			
Gzira	22	8	5	9	34	29	29			
Santa Lucia	22	7	5	10	20	31	26			
Mosta	22	5	9	8	14	27	24			
Valletta	22	4	8	10	18	23	20			
Sirens	22	1	6	15	11	44	9			
Gudja	22	0	6	16	12	52	6			



**MOSTA**

1

D. Akpan
N. Obidike
D. Aneni
H. Nwoga
P. Tenebe
W. Britto
N. Agius
J. Scerri
J. Vassallo
Z. Brincat
K. Tulimieri

**SANTA LUCIA**

1

F. Da Paz Silva
M. Ellul
S. Pisani
G. Mensah
T. Nagamatsu
A. Bradshaw
J. Pisani
N. Virano
P. De Oliveira
S. Xerri
E. Pinto

Referee: Trustin Farrugia Cann



**HAMRUN**

2

F. Marchetti
L. Montebello
J. Mbong
R. Prsa
E. Freitas da Silva
O. Bjelicic
J. Corbalan
C. Rutjens
E. Marcelina
R. Camenzuli
Jonny

**BIRKIRKARA**

0

M. Zapytowski
P. Mbong
A. Zammit
K. Zammit
A. Satariano
E. Pena Beltre
A. Coppola
E. Sarpong
S. Zibo
A. Diakite
A. Ciolacu

Referee: Slobodan Petrovic

BOV Player of the match: Luke Montebello (Hamrun)

Scorers: Montebello 21', 49' pen.
Yellow cards: Diakite, Coppola, Montebello, A. Zammit, K. Zammit
Red card: Diakite



**SLIEMA**

0

R. Al Tumi
J. Borg
V. Plut
M. Beerman
J. Arthur
G. Alcino
D. Kouao
N. Frendo
H. Freire
L. Micallef
A. Awad

**HIBERNIANS**

0

I. Kone
F. Apap
K. Shaw
S. Zuzul
J. Degabriele
A. De Souza
G. Artiles
C. Bonanni
M. Bagayoko
G. Bastianos
H. Fernandes

Referee: Malcolm Spiteri